

Chapter 25 - Dried Flowers

Chu Qingqiu's hand moved backward for a moment, as if instinctively wanting to hide the chrysanthemums behind her. However, how could her slender waist conceal such a large bouquet? So her hand moved halfway, then withdrew again.

Both seemed stunned for a moment. Neither spoke, only the white tiger that had followed Ning Fuyi up the steps huffed softly, walked between them, sat down, and began licking its paws with its legs crossed.

"Did your mother never teach you that visiting a Divine Venerable requires sending a calling card first? Moreover, I am now the sect leader. Do you still think of this Jingshan Palace as your home, just barging in as you please?" Chu Qingqiu finally spoke, her voice seeming to emerge through gritted teeth, no longer so composed.

"When has my mother ever sent you a calling card..." Ning Fuyi said quietly. "Besides, I originally intended to announce myself, but in such a vast Jingshan Palace with nothing but Bai Lin, who was I supposed to find to make the announcement? I couldn't just stand at the gate forever waiting for Your Venerable to come out."

"You..." Chu Qingqiu's red lips parted, but she ultimately held back and instead said coldly: "Bai Lin."

The little white tiger immediately perked up, its fur standing on end like a puffball.

"Letting anyone into my palace - what use are you as a guardian!"

The white tiger whimpered and hung its head dejectedly, looking apologetic.

"Go away." Chu Qingqiu said again. The white tiger spun in place and disappeared in a puff of white smoke.

Having said that, Chu Qingqiu no longer paid attention to Ning Fuyi and turned to walk inside, though her steps were somewhat hurried, diminishing her usual imposing presence.

Ning Fuyi was accustomed to being scolded by Chu Qingqiu, so her heart barely rippled. Or perhaps her attention was now drawn to other things - like that bouquet of chrysanthemums that she had clearly thrown back to the funeral shop.

Why had it appeared in Chu Qingqiu's hands again?

So she lifted her feet to follow Chu Qingqiu. However, before entering the door, the doorframe suddenly blazed with white light, and Ning Fuyi abruptly stopped.

"Get out." Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

Ning Fuyi glanced at the barrier on the doorframe, wordlessly reached out her hand, and casually poked it, easily breaking through the white membrane. She then watched with satisfaction as Chu Qingqiu's composure crumbled once again.

"Divine Venerable, the marriage contract¹." She smiled.

She loved seeing Chu Qingqiu suffer setbacks. Each rare glimpse was more entertaining than any mortal world theater.

Then she took a big step forward, entered the room, and assumed a respectful posture with her hands folded in front of her chest, bowing and saying: "This disciple greets the Divine Venerable. Today, Elder Yuanming instructed me to come and personally deliver the Crimson Jade Sect Seal to you."

As she spoke, she pulled out that broken stone from her bosom and presented it with both hands.

Chu Qingqiu probably wanted to send her away quickly, so unusually she didn't scold her further. Instead, she slightly turned her body, casually placed the flower vase in a concealed spot behind the curtain, and nodded: "Just put it down."

Ning Fuyi glanced at her, quickly walked a few steps with her head down, placed the stone on the desk, then looked up.

Chu Qingqiu was staring at her, and she was also looking at Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu's dark eyebrows were almost knitted together, her gaze clearly saying "why aren't you leaving yet." But Ning Fuyi deliberately pretended not to notice, leaning her body slightly to one side, her gaze passing over Chu Qingqiu's shoulder to look at the flower stems peeking out from behind the curtain.

"The Divine Venerable has always loved gardenias². How is it you're now keeping chrysanthemums? These flowers look quite familiar..." Ning Fuyi said with a smile in her eyes. "They're remarkably similar to the ones I gave you that day."

Chu Qingqiu's breathing paused for a moment, then she suddenly snorted coldly: "This venerable merely thought the white chrysanthemums looked nice and kept a bouquet. What business is it of yours? The item has been delivered - leave quickly."

"I see." Ning Fuyi nodded as if suddenly understanding, but her eyes examined the bouquet up and down. Though somewhat wilted and no longer blooming as vigorously as a few days ago, both the quantity and size were nearly identical to the bouquet she had bought.

Could Chu Qingqiu really like this bouquet of chrysanthemums so much that she retrieved it?

Surely it couldn't be because she had given them... But this thought was quickly dismissed with a shake of her head. What kind of person was Chu Qingqiu? So lofty and unapproachable - how could she possibly care about a bouquet of flowers someone else gave her?

Especially when that someone was herself.

"You got another bouquet? I feel they're really familiar, and the ones I bought included one with rare red stamens." Ning Fuyi stepped forward to get closer again, but suddenly a cold wind blew past her face, her hair fluttering slightly as White Bone appeared directly in front of her face.

Ning Fuyi quickly retreated, tilting her nose aside to avoid the fierce light glowing on White Bone's surface.

Fine, teasing her for some amusement was enough. She shouldn't really provoke this person to anger, Ning Fuyi thought. So before Chu Qingqiu could scold her, she spoke first, blocking the anger that was about to emerge.

"Divine Venerable, don't be hasty. I have no other meaning - I just want to tell you that you're caring for these flowers incorrectly." She spoke extremely quickly.

Sure enough, Chu Qingqiu, who had been furious just moments before, paused and slowly lowered the White Bone in her hand. Though her tone was still cold, she at least didn't drive her out again.

"How is it incorrect?" she asked.

"Look here." Ning Fuyi turned and walked around her, taking a few steps to the curtain and bringing out the flower vase. The vase was made of precious gold-threaded glass, with shimmering golden threads flowing through the crystal-clear glass - magical and dreamlike.

Using such a rare vessel to keep chrysanthemums - it seemed Chu Qingqiu really did like them, Ning Fuyi thought.

"When keeping flowers in water, you need to remove the lower branches and leaves." Ning Fuyi placed the vase back on the desk and flicked the vase body with her finger. "Just stuffing them in like this - it's no wonder they won't keep well. Besides, it's been several days since we returned from Furong Town. Even the freshest chrysanthemums kept in water would wither within eight or nine days."

Chu Qingqiu's peach blossom eyes lowered, her gaze falling on the petals: "So it seems, then it's beyond salvation."

Ning Fuyi didn't understand and couldn't help asking: "The Divine Venerable has supreme divine powers. You could just cast a spell to revive them - why worry about it?"

"Immortal arts can restore them to their former state, but they would no longer be the same flowers." After Chu Qingqiu finished speaking, she gently turned around, her soft sleeves spreading like butterfly wings before falling. "You may go."

Her tone carried some melancholy. Ning Fuyi looked at her back, then at the flowers on the desk that had reached their twilight, and suddenly spoke: "Actually, if you want to preserve their current appearance without using immortal arts, it's not difficult."

"That's unnecessary. They're just an unimportant bouquet. If they wither, they wither."

Hmph, she clearly wants them very much, Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

She glanced at the flowers, said nothing more, but instead pulled them out of the vase with her hand, then untied her sash from her waist, tying one end to the bottom of the bouquet and the other to the window frame, hanging them upside down.

Hearing the sound, Chu Qingqiu turned around but said nothing. She silently watched Ning Fuyi's actions until Ning Fuyi kept waving her hands under the flowers but couldn't produce anything, then she couldn't help asking: "What are you doing?"

Ning Fuyi wasn't yet skilled at transformation arts, and she hadn't learned fire-type immortal techniques. She had no choice but to turn around and say: "Divine Venerable, may I borrow some fire?"

Chu Qingqiu lightly flicked her fingertip, and flames immediately burst forth under the flowers. The temperature in the room rose instantly, and the moisture in the air gradually became sparse. When the petals were half-dry, Ning Fuyi extinguished the fire and picked up the flowers again.

However, her long skirt hem caught fire as she stood up, and part of the silk skirt was burned away. Ning Fuyi stamped on it a few times and paid no attention.

But Chu Qingqiu's gaze lingered on that skirt hem for a while.

"You'll know in a moment." Ning Fuyi also became playful. She clapped her hands and ran downstairs. Chu Qingqiu didn't understand her actions but didn't stop her either. Instead, she stood up and looked through the window.

Ning Fuyi's figure soon appeared downstairs. She ran to the pond, gathered a bundle of fine sand in her clothes, then returned upstairs with light steps.

After hearing her sounds, Chu Qingqiu immediately moved away from the window and pretended she hadn't moved at all.

"Divine Venerable, do you have a glass box?" Ning Fuyi asked with a forehead full of sweat.

Chu Qingqiu looked at her feet covered in mud and sand, finally restraining herself from getting angry. She coldly took down a box from a nearby treasure shelf, removed the jade cup that was originally inside, and casually tossed it aside.

"The Divine Venerable is quite generous." Ning Fuyi smiled.

"It wasn't mine to begin with." Chu Qingqiu replied. She pushed the glass box toward Ning Fuyi and restrained herself from showing her curiosity.

Ning Fuyi nodded. She snapped her fingers and used immortal power to cut the flower stems in half, then held the flowers in one hand while pouring all the fine sand from her clothes into the box with the other. The fine sand filled half the glass box, leaving only the upper space for the flowers. The translucent box paired with the snow-white petals was like a half-concealed beauty, bashfully beautiful.

Chu Qingqiu moved forward half a step, her shoulders slightly bent as she leaned closer to look at the box.

"These are dried flowers. When mortals don't know immortal arts but want to preserve flowers, they do this." Ning Fuyi finally explained. "From now on, there's no need to water them. Just leave them like this and wait for them to completely dry."

In the past, she didn't like cultivation and would often sneak down the mountain to play in the mortal world, learning some small tricks from mortals that were sometimes more interesting than immortal arts.

Chu Qingqiu unconsciously nodded, then felt she had agreed too quickly. She clasped her hands behind her back, straightened up, and made a cold "hmm" sound.

Seeing her wanting to look but restraining herself, Ning Fuyi felt inexplicably pleased. Though she still disliked Chu Qingqiu very much, she had to admit that this Chu Qingqiu with a touch of humanity was more approachable than the emotionless Divine Venerable of the past.

"The item has been delivered. This disciple takes her leave." Ning Fuyi was also too lazy to stay longer. She turned to walk out, but the corner of her robe that had been burned by fire earlier fluttered in the air, exposing itself to Chu Qingqiu's eyes.

"Stop." Chu Qingqiu suddenly said.

Ning Fuyi stopped suspiciously and looked down following Chu Qingqiu's gaze, then kicked her skirt hem back.

"Has Elder Jingshan not yet prepared your sect robes³?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"Not yet." Ning Fuyi answered. Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's sect robes were only given after breaking through the Mortal Realm. They were woven from Cloud Silk and imbued with immortal power by senior cultivators, making them waterproof, fireproof, warm in winter, and cool in summer.

"Elder Jingshan manages disciples' food, clothing, and housing. How could he be so negligent?" Chu Qingqiu's beautiful brows furrowed again.

"This disciple is dull-witted and naturally not valued. Breaking through the Mortal Realm was also just luck. The elders have many important matters - forgetting is normal." Ning Fuyi said. "This disciple takes her leave."

She said no more and clip-clopped away. Only Chu Qingqiu remained in the room. She exhaled and turned to look at the box containing the dried flowers, her pale fingers touching it lightly, gently caressing.

In those pale eyes that had always overflowed with coldness, a rare gentleness slowly rippled forth.

Noise arose from downstairs. Chu Qingqiu walked to the window to look - it was Ning Fuyi, who was about to leave, running head-first into Qiu Yi. The two exchanged words back and forth, arguing. In the end, Ning Fuyi clearly had the upper hand, strutting away with her chest out, leaving Qiu Yi stamping her feet in place.

Watching this scene, the corners of Chu Qingqiu's lips moved almost imperceptibly.

"Qiu Yi." she called out through the air. After a short while, the red-faced Qiu Yi stood outside the door and said "Master" with undiminished anger.

"That waste... Ning Fuyi went too far, barging into Jingshan Palace without saying a word, disturbing Master's rest." Qiu Yi was agitated and was about to continue complaining when Chu Qingqiu interrupted her.

"I wanted to ask you - do you know needlework?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"Needlework?" Qiu Yi was stunned. In her mind, her master had always focused solely on cultivation, having no interest in romance, and was completely ignorant about food, clothing, and daily life. She wouldn't even open doors with her own hands.

What earthly miracle had occurred for her to want to do needlework now?

Author's Notes:

Chu Qingqiu: You don't understand - this is love.

Footnotes:

1. **Marriage contract (婚契)** - Refers to the forced engagement contract between Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu that makes Chu Qingqiu unable to harm her
 2. **Gardenias (梔子)** - White fragrant flowers often associated with purity and elegance in Chinese culture
 3. **Sect robes (门服)** - Special ceremonial clothing worn by sect members, typically indicating rank and providing magical protection
-

Author's Notes: This chapter beautifully shows Chu Qingqiu's hidden tender feelings through her secret preservation of Ning Fuyi's gift. The dried flower tutorial becomes a metaphor for preserving precious memories exactly as they are, while the ending hints at Chu Qingqiu's growing desire to care for Ning Fuyi in practical ways like making her proper clothing.